Aditya Gupta returned to Bhopal after completing his computer science degree in his early twenties but didn't end up taking the path his credentials suggested. He knew he wanted to enter his family's agricultural business right out of the college gates, sidestepping the midlife crisis that Indian engineers often face when they realise this was never what they wanted to do with their lives anyway. He decided to get into poultry but chose the egg business, avoiding the sale of chicken for meat—and his life would never be the same.

The young engineer interned for six months at RS Agro, a poultry farm on the outskirts of Bhopal owned by a man soon to become his mentor. He learnt the nitty-gritty of the business and eventually set up his own venture, for years leading a routine where he would reach the farm at 4 am, before cockcrow, and return home only at 9 pm. Things seemed humdrum for a good long while until suddenly, in 2018, tragedy struck. A cancer diagnosis. His own possible mortality, and the role his nutrition might have had in increasing susceptibility to the disease, made him fast-track any ambitions that had been on the backburner. He decided to pay attention to one in particular, related to his business: making healthier feed for poultry so that the eggs produced by them are safer and healthier.

"Whenever a bird died at the farm, we would carry out a post-mortem to determine the cause of death. We found that commercial feed was causing trouble, and medicines, especially antibiotics, had limitations. That's when I began reading up on ayurveda and how herbs could be used to create healthier feed," says Aditya.

FACT SHEET

Name of company
Aditya Poultry

What it does: **Sells nutrient-rich eggs by feeding poultry a patented diet**

Founded in: **2019**

Annual turnover
Rs 1 crore

> **"WE FOUND THAT COMMERCIAL FEED WAS CAUSING TROUBLE WITH POULTRY... EGGS PRODUCED BY BIRDS ON A HERBAL DIET ARE HIGH ON NUTRIENTS AND FLAVONOIDS AND ENHANCE IMMUNITY"**
>
> **ADITYA GUPTA**

It was three years and many reams of research later that he finally ended up applying for a patent for his poultry feed composition. A wait of another three years, and he secured one from the Indian Patents Office. He is now a veteran of the process, having applied for five more in India and three in the United States for a specialised feed that produces eggs that are low in cholesterol and fat, and high in omega 5 and omega 7 fatty acids. A sizable number of people complain of allergies traced to the consumption of eggs. The hypoallergenic eggs brought out by Aditya have successfully completed human trials—they hold out the promise of not producing the allergic reactions caused by regular eggs. "Eggs produced by birds on a herbal diet are high on proteins, minerals, vitamins and flavonoids and enhance immunity in those who consume them," says Aditya, adding that the feed made by him has 200 to 250 herbs—the eggs, thus, offer as a package deal what would otherwise be a distant dietary rainbow for most.

All this while, though, he had help. When he was in and out of hospitals, his wife Disha rose to the occasion to handle the backend of the business. She had no experience with this family calling of birds and eggs, but had a knack for marketing and distributing her husband's innovation. When COVID struck, demand for his eggs started coming in from hospitals due to their reputation for improving immunity and so, because Bhopal was on lockdown and none of their employees were around, the couple drove around the city themselves distributing eggs at hospitals.

Plans for expansion? Many. Aditya says, "All the herbs going in the feed have medicinal properties. While I know the eggs are fit for consumption by those with egg allergies, there is a cure for other diseases I am working on too. For example, omega 7 is known to work on obesity." Could this be the start of an Ayurvedic egg revolution? ■